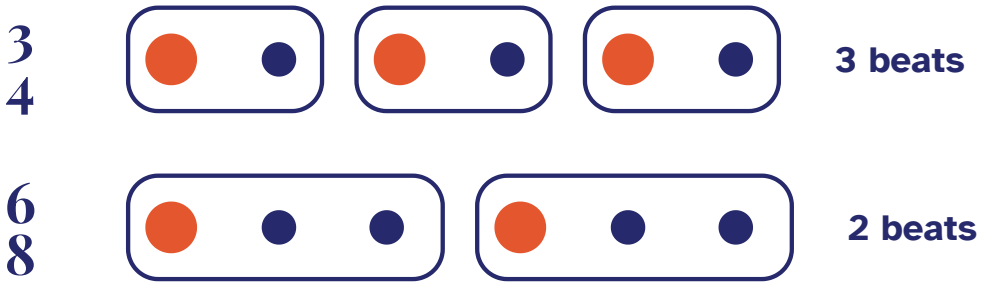
PART II · TIME · 5

Compound and irregular time

Compound time skips: each dotted beat splits into **three**. Irregular time keeps you guessing, with **five or seven** counts in uneven groups. (9/4, 12/4 and /16 signatures are rare.)

THE SECRET

Dotted beats split in three: 6/8 is two big beats.



Same six quavers, new groups

SIMPLE OR COMPOUND?

In **simple time** each beat divides into **two**. In **compound time** each beat is a dotted note and divides into **three**.

Quick test: a top number of 6, 9 or 12 means compound. Divide it by 3 to find the beats: 6/8 has 2, 9/8 has 3, 12/8 has 4.

Compound time

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
6/8	2 dotted crotchets	Level 1
9/8	3 dotted crotchets	Level 3
12/8	4 dotted crotchets	Level 3
6/4	2 dotted minims	Level 4

Counting 6/8



Slowly, count all six quavers. At speed, feel two beats, on 1 and 4: “1 & a, 2 & a”.

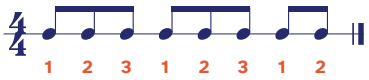
PART II · TIME · 5 · CONTINUED

Irregular time

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
5/4	5 crotchets: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	Level 5
7/4	7 crotchets: 4 + 3 or 3 + 4	*Extra*
5/8	5 quavers: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	*Extra*
7/8	7 quavers: 2 + 2 + 3 or 3 + 2 + 2	*Extra*

UNEVEN GROUPS IN 4/4

Many dances keep 4/4 but group the eight quavers 3 + 3 + 2: “1 2 3, 1 2 3, 1 2”.



GAME

Two beats or three?

1	2
6/8	3/4
3	4
9/8	2/4

How many beats in a bar, and does each beat split in two or in three?

Answer: 1 two, in threes · 2 three, in twos · 3 three, in threes · 4 two, in twos.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
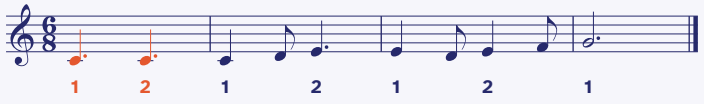
6/8

Sway left, sway right.

Say “1 2 3, 4 5 6” and sway once on 1 and once on 4. That is 6/8: six quavers, two big beats.

YOU KNOW THIS

Row, Row, Row Your Boat



Two big beats in every bar, each a **dotted crotchet**: “Row, row”. Inside each beat, “gent-ly” splits it into three. That is 6/8.

Try it. Sway twice per bar while you sing it.

THINK OF IT Like a skipping rope: two big swings, each with three little steps inside.

SEE ALSO
Time signatures p. 41 · Rhythm: groups and upbeats p. 45

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Levels 1–4 · Compound time · Online: Rhythm clock